SUNY Old Westbury 2026-2027 Undergraduate Catalog

Course Descriptions

Contract All Courses |

Politics, Economics and Law

PH 4430 - Health Economics

Credits: 4

Health Economics provides a broad overview of healthcare delivery and finance systems, both in the U.S. and abroad, and explores the role that economic theory plays in the national healthcare reform debate. The student will be introduced to a number of basic theoretical tools used in economics to explain the allocation of scarce resources in healthcare markets. The course will also explore a number of controversial questions involving the rationing of care, "market failures" in the current healthcare system, disparities in access to care, and the extent to which recent healthcare reform legislation addresses these issues.

Prerequisites

Upper division status

Note:

This is cross-listed with PE 4430

Public Health

PH 2000 - Introduction to Public Health

Credits: 4

This course provides an equity-focused overview to the fundamentals of public health, which is focused on the health of entire communities and populations, rather than individuals. Public health examines the health of communities as shaped by political, economic, cultural, environmental, behavioral, and biological factors. Public health practitioners focus on promoting the health of populations through research, policy, education and interventions.

This course introduces the history, science, and principles of public health, as well as opportunities to learn about current issues and approaches in the field. It also provides a broad overview of population health in the United States, as well as grounding for students to wish to pursue additional coursework in public health.

When Offered:

Fall and Spring

PH 2450 - Human Sexuality

Credits: 4

This course teaches the dynamics of human sexual health including the interplay of biological, cultural, social, historical, and political-economic elements. Drawing from a public health perspective, students learn anatomy and physiology, explore contemporary sexual health issues, and learn tools to promote sexual health.

Prerequisites

None

PH 2900 - Black Lives Matter: Health Inequities in the U.S.

Credits: 4

In this course, students will develop a deep understanding of the ubiquitous health inequities impacting Black communities in the United States. Students will also develop an understanding of the determinants of these inequities; the deleterious social conditions to which Black people in the United States have been disproportionately exposed since Africans were first displaced and uprooted from their communities, families and lives, and sold into chattel slavery in the colonies. Students will also develop a deep and historicized understanding of the currently entrenched political structures which reproduce Black exposure to the health-demoting social conditions, comparatively fewer socioeconomic resources, and traumatic social stressors that produce and reproduce shorter and less healthy Black lives. Students will also come to understand that none of these patterns are inevitable, and none of these political structures spontaneously emerged. They are the product of policies, and therefore are certainly changeable. We will examine the types of policies that have the potential to change the path of history, by creating more equitable life chances for Black people and communities. In doing so, these policies can help us better fulfill the promises of the Constitution, and create health equality.

Prerequisites

None

PH 3200 - Nutrition, Health, and the Food System

Credits: 4

Access to healthy, safe, and affordable food is a major determinant of health. This course will examine the economic, social and political forces that determine the availability, quality and healthfulness of the food we are exposed to in our daily lives. Students will learn to critique the perspective that healthy eating is simply a question of 'individual choice,' examine the constraints and limitations within which we make our 'choices,' and also critically examine popular media messaging that exhorts us to eat healthy food while also promoting the popular view that only unhealthy food tastes good. Students will learn about community-based efforts to improve the health of our communities by improving the quality of our food.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 3300 - Foundations of Maternal and Child Health

Credits: 4

This interdisciplinary course explores core topics in Maternal and Child Health (MCH) through a public health, social justice, and life course lens. The curriculum examines reproductive and birth justice, pregnancy, labor and delivery, postpartum care, breastfeeding, child development from 0-3 years, and the structural determinants shaping health outcomes. Students will critically examine health systems, disparities, and culturally competent models of care, including hospital births, home births, and birthing centers.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 3325 - Breastfeeding and Human Lactation: A Public Health Perspective

Credits: 4

This course explores breastfeeding and human lactation through a public health lens, focusing on biological, social, cultural, and structural factors that influence breastfeeding practices globally and in the United States. Emphasis will be placed on lactation equity, breastfeeding promotion and policy, and the intersection of race, gender, class, and structural racism. The course prepares students to advocate for and implement evidence-based programs that support breastfeeding as a key component of maternal and child health.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 3400 - International Study Abroad

Credits: 4

This course examines contemporary public health issues, including successes and challenges, affecting a country outside the US and examines responses to address them. Students attend lectures, participate in cultural activities, and meet with local public health officials, researchers, community leaders, and organizations during the study abroad trip. Students compare the chosen country's public health system to the US health care system. The location of the study abroad program varies. The course may be repeated once for credit if the course topic changes.

Prerequisites

None

PH 3600 - Introduction to the Social Determinants of Health

Credits: 4

Introduces students to the public health perspective on health, also called the social determinants of health, which includes a detailed examination of social class, racism, gender, community, environment, employment, social relationships, nutrition and the American food system, as well as access to health care. Students learn about numerous American institutions, and examine critically how individuals' location in American society shapes their health status. They also learn to locate individual health behavior within its social context.

Prerequisites

EMS

When Offered:

Fall and Spring

PH 3610 - Introduction to the U.S. Health Care System

Credits: 4

Students will examine the history and institutions of the health care system, and examine concepts and terminology crucial to understanding both the history and current structure of the health care system. The course also focuses on modes of health care financing, quality of care, inequalities in care, and historical and contemporary issues in health care reform. Throughout the course, students apply what they are learning in order to develop scientifically informed strategies to improve the health care system's ability to promote population health.

Prerequisites

EMS

When Offered:

Fall and Spring**Note:**

PH 3600 is NOT a prerequisite for PH 3610

PH 3700 - Medical Anthropology

Credits: 4

Medical anthropology considers the cultural, social, and political-economic aspects of the body, health, sickness, and healing in the cross-cultural perspective. Students will learn major anthropological concepts of disease and illness, including biocultural analyses of health and disease, the social patterning of disease, cultural critiques of biomedicine, and non-Western systems of health, illness, and healing. Students will examine how anthropology is applied to medicine, nursing, and public health.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 3750 - Mass Incarceration: A Public Health Crisis

Credits: 4

In this interdisciplinary course students will learn about the roots of policing in the United States. They will also understand historical shifts in the US carceral system, and how these shifts intersect with trends in the prevalence of crime, as well as the genesis and population health consequences of mass incarceration. Students will understand the direct health impacts of incarceration, as well as the mechanisms through which mass incarceration shapes population health equity; in particular, through its impact on the community and social networks of the incarcerated and those populations routinely criminalized and subjected to hyper-surveillance.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 3850 - Global Health

Credits: 4

Examines health problems, health status, public health policies and programs and the role of global politics and economics in determining the health status of people worldwide. The health systems of a number of countries are also examined. Local connections to global health are examined.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4600 - Health Program Planning and Evaluation

Credits: 4

This course provides a comprehensive overview of community health needs assessment, program planning and evaluation in public health. Along with knowledge of behavior change theories and evidence-based best practices of health programs, students will gain skills necessary for data collection, health program design, and implementation at multiple levels.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4610 - Women's Health

Credits: 4

A critical review of women's health topics and gendered health inequalities from the perspective of the women's health movement. This course offers medical and alternative views of topics such as reproductive anatomy and physiology; sexuality; gender identity; reproductive justice; STIs; pregnancy, childbirth, and parenting; infertility; aging and menopause; health issues; health care providers; and gender inequities in health research.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4631 - Mental Health

Credits: 4

The course will provide students with a multidisciplinary (public health, sociology, anthropology, epidemiology, and psychology) understanding of the field of mental health. Topics will include: concepts of mental health and mental illness; community and clinical mental health systems; social inequalities in the risk for mental ill-health; stigma and discrimination; human rights and individuals with mental illnesses; mental health issues in low resource countries and humanitarian settings; stress, trauma, and resiliency; and other selected topics.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4650 - Substance Use: Social and structural determinants

Credits: 4

This course will provide an overview of substance use, addiction, and treatment (alcohol, tobacco, cannabis, stimulants, psychedelics, depressants, opiates) through the lenses of public health, medicine, history, public policy, media, and the arts. In this course we will apply a critical perspective to examine topics including: social and structural risk factors for

substance use disorders; treatment modalities, settings, and outcomes; the racial politics of drug panics and policing of populations; cross-country comparisons of substance use and treatment policies; and other historical and contemporary issues.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4661 - Health Education

Credits: 4

Students will examine and gain an understanding of the theoretical frameworks informing health education strategies at the individual, social and structural levels. Students analyze the methods and techniques employed in developing and conducting health education interventions. In addition, students will learn how to critically assess and apply health education theories.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4670 - Biostatistics

Credits: 4

This course introduces statistical methods and principles essential for understanding and interpreting public health data, with emphasis on real-world applications. Topics include descriptive statistics, correlation, inference, hypothesis testing (e.g. T-test, Chi-Square test), analysis of variance, and simple linear regression. Upon completion, students will gain the competence in applying statistical methods to analyze health-related data for decision-making in public health.

Prerequisites

MA 2000; EMS

When Offered:

Fall and Spring

PH 4680 - Environmental Health

Credits: 4

This course examines the relationship of people to their physical and social environment, the impact of the environment on population health and well-being, and approaches to combating local and global environmental health problems. Topics include air, soil, and water pollution; exposure, dose, response; risk assessment and management; occupational health; environmental justice and policy; and urban and global environmental health problems, including climate change.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4750 - Aging and Social Policy

Credits: 4

Introduces students to fundamental aspects of aging and health, with a primary focus on the United States. Beginning with an overview of the social-scientific study of aging, it examines theories of aging, factors influencing health in older adults including social support, living arrangements, work and retirement, and health care and caregiving. It includes an economic analysis of aging, with a focus on issues of health, poverty and inequality.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4760 - Health Administration

Credits: 4

Introduces management and planning concepts and their application to the health field. Attention is paid to system-wide considerations, e.g., methods of health care regulation and cost containment, as well as to techniques and concepts used in managing health care organizations. Managerial and regulatory processes are emphasized. Students are encouraged to relate organizational capabilities to the larger social, political, and economic environment.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4770 - Occupational Health

Credits: 4

Examines the legal, economic, and political foundations of occupational health work in the U.S. The roles of government, unions, corporations, and research organizations are examined. Students review the scientific basis for the association of occupational exposures with disease, including occupational cancer and respiratory disease.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4790 - Health Policy

Credits: 4

Identifies and analyzes the political forces acting in the health care sector and examines their relationship to the U.S. political scene. Debates over health policy are traced historically and related to major policy issues in U.S. history. Special attention is paid to coalition building; the possibility of reform; the development of the idea that health care is a right; and private influence on the functioning of public agencies; policy formation and government involvement in health care.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4800 - Epidemiology

Credits: 4

An introduction to the field of epidemiology, students learn how to interpret and apply epidemiologic measures used to describe the occurrence of morbidity and mortality in populations. The course will focus on the major sources of epidemiologic data, and the analysis and critique of epidemiologic study designs. Social epidemiologic theories and applications, causal pathways, community-based approaches, and methods used to respond to public health crises will

also be examined. Students will learn the skills necessary to becoming critical consumers of epidemiologic literature, and will be able to use the tools of epidemiology in order to understand, describe and develop strategies to improve population health and reduce health inequalities.

Prerequisites

EMS

When Offered:

Fall and Spring

PH 4810 - Ethics in Public Health

Credits: 4

This course begins with a brief history and overview of the field of medical ethics, and then focuses on the application of moral values and principles relevant to public health and medical practice through a variety of case studies. Students will complete the required federal training for researchers working with human subjects. The course aims to develop students' knowledge of ethics and their ability to think critically and ethically about complex issues such as genetic engineering, assisted reproduction, stem cell research, organ donation, care of newborns and end-of-life decision-making, and the challenges that policymakers face in determining how to allocate resources and manage conflicts between individual freedoms and the public good.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4820 - Health Law

Credits: 4

Designed to give prospective health professionals an understanding of the terminology and concepts of health law. Attention focuses on public health law, medical care law, and health facility law. Historical and contemporary issues are examined via case review readings and discussions. Issues include the right to health care, informed consent, malpractice and product liability.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4890 - Environmental Justice

Credits: 4

The health of our environment is central to our ability to lead healthy lives. This course examines the social, political, and economic forces that shape our exposure to environmental benefits and harms depending on our location in society. Students will learn what environmental justice is and how to assess it, as well as how to employ a variety of methods to promote environmental health in communities, including policy, regulations, and grassroots activism. Topics include air and water pollution, food and agriculture, urbanization and global climate change. The course draws on examples from the United States and around the world.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4900 - Applied Practice Experience

Credits: 4

The student interns for 90 hours in a community health agency or health organization, with prior approval of the instructor. This course provides an opportunity for students to integrate classroom learning with practical work experience. Depending on their interests, students work in a wide variety of health settings. For example, students may assess community health needs and contribute to health-equity focused interventions in health care delivery systems. Students meet regularly to discuss their experiences, maintain a log of their activities, and write a final paper describing the agency, summarizing their work, and reflecting on their future career goals

Prerequisites

EMS, PH 2000

When Offered:

Fall and Spring

PH 4920 - Special Topics in Public Health

Credits: 4

This course gives students the opportunity to examine in greater depth a topic of special interest in public health. The specific topic will be determined by the instructor. The course may be repeated once for credit if the course topic changes.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 4930 - Immigrant and Refugee Health

Credits: 4

This course introduces students to theories of migration, historical immigration policies and the major health issues faced by immigrants and refugees in the United States. Upon completion of this course, students will have a comprehensive understanding of factors leading to immigrants' health advantages and/or health inequities. Students will also learn about current law, policy and debates related to migrant health.

Prerequisites

EMS

PH 5900 - Senior Research Seminar I

Credits: 4

This course, the first of the 2-course research sequence for the Public Health major, introduces seniors to various the research tools for empirical studies across diverse sub-fields of public health. Students will learn to evaluate research studies, focusing on quantitative and qualitative methods. Topics include research assessment, scholarly writing, research design, ethical considerations, and data collection and analysis. Satisfactory completion of this course is required for advancing to PH 5920 - Senior Research Seminar II.

Prerequisites

EMS, PH 2000 and PH 3600**Prerequisite/Corequisite**

PH 4800

When Offered:

Fall and Spring

PH 5920 - Senior Research Seminar II

Credits: 4

The culmination of students' work in Public Health. Seniors in their final year will have assignments that demonstrate their ability to use, evaluate, and synthesize public health data, with specific attention to the social determinants of health framework, to address a public health issue. Students will communicate this synthesized public health information in both oral and written forms to diverse audiences using a social justice framework.

Prerequisites

EMS; PH 5900

When Offered:

Fall and Spring

PH 9990 - Independent Study

Credits: 4

Independent study, carried out under the supervision of a faculty member, permits students to investigate areas that are not part of existing offerings. Open to students of upper-division standing only.

Prerequisites

PH 3600

and PH 3610

; permission of instructor

Sociology

PH 3800 - Medical Sociology

Credits: 4

Explores the social forces defining and influencing health and illness. The organization and distribution of medical science and professionals are analyzed from a sociological perspective, with an emphasis on care for the poor, minorities, women, the disabled, and the aged. Alternatives to the present system of medical care in the U.S. are discussed, particularly in the context of health and medical care in other countries.

Prerequisites

Writing O.W.

When Offered:

Every Year**Note:**

This is cross-listed with SY 3750, Medical Sociology

Contract All Courses |